

MINUTES
VANCE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS
BUDGET WORK SESSION
June 16, 2025

The Vance County Board of Commissioners held a budget work session on Monday, June 16, 2025 at 4:00 p.m. in the Commissioners' Conference Room, Vance County Administration Building, 122 Young Street, Henderson, NC. Those commissioners present were as follows: Chair Carolyn Faines, Vice-Chair Yolanda J. Feimster, Commissioners R. Dan Brummitt, Charisse Fain, Thomas S. Hester, Jr., Leo Kelly, Jr., and Valencia Perry.

Absent: None

Also present were County Manager C. Renee Perry, Assistant County Manager Jeremy Jones, Finance Director Stephanie Williams, and Special Projects Coordinator Frankie Nobles.

The purpose of the work session was to continue to review and discuss the proposed budget for FY 2025-26.

County Manager C. Renee Perry provided a follow-up from the May 20th budget work session. Notable changes to the proposed budget included:

- 6.78% increase in city water rates
- Code Enforcement to remain as is until the city creates its own department in September
- Kerr Lake Substation – debt service falling off this year
- Foster Care Clothing – increase from \$10,000 to \$60,000
- Solid Waste Household Fee – increase from \$125 to \$146 to be self-sustaining
- VGCC Capital Reserve Account created – \$500,000
- Teacher supplement increased from \$2,500 to \$3,500, plus 2% increase for classified positions
- Salary study implementation removed from proposed budget; 3% COLA instead
- Library budget increased by \$63,000 due to health insurance increase
- Property and Liability increased by \$85,000 due to liability concerns with DSS and Jail
- Total budget increased by \$1,449,418
- Fund balance appropriated - \$4,068,875

The board discussed possible ways to decrease the overall budget. Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr. floated the idea of dissolving the rescue squad and merging with the county fire department. He noted that the county has funded the rescue squad over \$785,000 over the past three years. The rescue squad provides heavy rescue (extrication), water rescue, and provides a cascade system on scene which refills firefighters' breathing apparatus. Chair Faines asked if the county department is trained and equipped for these purposes. Fire Chief Marvin Harrison was present and stated that we do have trained personnel, but the county department does not own a cascade system. He noted that Watkins VFD has one and Cokesbury VFD is in the process of acquiring one. Fire Association President Brandon Link stated that a cascade system was purchased by the fire association and is housed at the rescue squad but is not owned by the rescue squad. It can be used by any department.

Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr. noted that between the county fire department and volunteer departments, there are over 50 people trained to perform rescue duties. It was noted that the county can purchase equipment needed such as a cascade system, underwater drone, and watercraft, and still save money overall. Major William Mitchell with the Sheriff's Office stated that the Sheriff's Office is actively pursuing grants to create a dive team.

Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt recommended changing the county fire department to a combination volunteer department and maintaining the rescue squad. County Manager C. Renee Perry responded that the fire study conducted a few years ago did not recommend doing this. It was also noted that finding qualified volunteers is getting more and more difficult. Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt disagreed.

Ms. Perry noted that the current three-year contract with the rescue squad expires June 30, 2025. The board discussed the contract and decided to extend it for 90 days. This will provide the county time to purchase its own equipment. This matter will be placed on the July 7 regular meeting agenda in order to hear from the rescue squad.

Social Services. Ms. Brenda Brown with DHHS appeared before the board to request a stand-alone Social Worker Program Administrator II position to focus solely on child welfare. Ms. Perry recommended a Social Worker Program Administrator I position, not II. DSS Director Sandy Weaver was present and recommended a Social Worker Program Manager position instead of a Social Worker Program Administrator position to be compliant with the state. Ms. Perry stated that she would work with DHHS to see what the position needs to be.

Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt asked several questions about various line items including animal services, social services, inspections, recreation, RTRP, dues and subscriptions, tax office, legal fees, detention center, etc.

A special called meeting was scheduled for Monday, June 23 at 4:00 p.m. to adopt the budget.

As there was no further business, the work session was adjourned.